MESALAZINE

Brands not interchangeable

Monitor renal function

CHEMICAL NAME 5-amino-2-hydroxybenzoic acid (5-aminosalicylic acid, 5-ASA)
CLASS Aminosalicylate (5-ASA) anti-inflammatory for IBD
TRADE NAMES Asacol · Pentasa · Salofalk · Mezavant / Lialda

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Ulcerative colitis; induction and maintenance of remission (first-line for mild–moderate).
- Crohn's disease (limited benefit).
- Distal colitis/proctitis (suppositories, enemas).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** delayed-/prolonged-release tablets or granules — swallow whole, do not crush/chew; prescribe by brand.
- **PR** suppositories at bedtime; enemas/foam — retain as long as possible.

DOSAGES

- **Active UC (oral):** 2.4–4.8 g/day in divided or once-daily doses.
- **Maintenance:** 1.2–2.4 g/day.
- **Suppositories:** 1 g at bedtime.
- **Children:** 30–50 mg/kg/day (specialist).

PHARMACOKINETICS

- Formulations release drug in ileum/colon (pH- or time-dependent).
- Acetylated in gut wall and liver.
- Excreted in urine and faeces. **t½:** 0.5–1.5 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Acts topically on colonic mucosa: inhibits prostaglandin and leukotriene production, scavenges free radicals, inhibits NF-κB → ↓ inflammation.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Headache, nausea, abdominal pain.
- Diarrhoea, rash.
- Flatulence.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Interstitial nephritis / nephrotoxicity.
- Blood dyscrasias (agranulocytosis, aplastic anaemia).
- Pancreatitis; myocarditis/pericarditis.
- Acute intolerance syndrome (mimics colitis flare); SJS.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Salicylate hypersensitivity.
- Severe renal (eGFR <30) or hepatic impairment.
- **Caution:** elderly, bleeding disorders.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Azathioprine, mercaptopurine:** ↑ myelosuppression.
- **Nephrotoxic drugs (NSAIDs):** ↑ renal risk.
- **Lactulose, antacids:** may alter release from pH-dependent forms.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Baseline renal function, CBC, LFTs; renal function at 3 months then yearly.
- Monitor stool frequency, blood, abdominal pain.
- Report unexplained bleeding, bruising, sore throat, fever.
- Teach suppository/enema technique.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Swallow tablets whole; stick to the same brand.
- Report sore throat, fever, bruising or bleeding immediately.
- Keep taking during remission to prevent flares.
- Tablet shells may appear in stool (some brands).

KEY POINTS

- 5-ASA — first-line for mild–moderate UC.
- Brands not interchangeable.
- Topical action in colon.
- Monitor renal function and CBC.